

Musical instruments

From very early times, people have enjoyed making music by beating, plucking, rattling, or blowing into instruments. Different groups of instruments are known as “families”. In an orchestra, many of them come together to combine their sounds.

WOODWIND

These wind instruments are made of metal and plastic, as well as wood. Holes in the pipe are opened and closed with the fingers to change the notes. Some woodwind instruments use a vibrating strip, called a reed, as a mouthpiece.



INTERNATIONAL INSTRUMENTS

Round the world, music-making involves a huge variety of traditional instruments. Many are unique to particular countries or cultures.



THE ORCHESTRA

Large orchestras have followed the same seating arrangement for their musicians since the 18th century. The various instruments are positioned according to type.



KEY	
Conductor	Bassoons
First violins	Horns
Second violins	Trumpets
Violas	Trombones and tubas
Cellos	Harp
Double basses	Drums
Flutes	Other percussion
Oboes	Piano
Clarinets	

BRASS

The brass section of an orchestra makes some of the loudest sounds. When brass players blow air into their instruments, they put their lips close to the mouthpiece to create vibrations. Many types of brass have button-like valves that are pressed down to alter notes.

